

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Telecommunications English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For network operations staff, telecom engineers, field technicians, customer operations teams, product managers, regulatory staff, and telecom project leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Outage bridge

02 Fiber deployment dependency

03 Capacity or coverage?

04 Provisioning mismatch

05 Field dispatch handoff

06 Emergency-service change review

07 Churn-risk discussion

08 Equipment end of support

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Outage bridge

Network operations coordinates a service interruption.

Roles: NOC engineer / Incident coordinator

NOC engineer: We have loss-of-signal alarms on the eastern ring. Several enterprise circuits are affected.

Incident coordinator: Do we have a confirmed fault location or only correlated alarms?

NOC engineer: Only the alarms so far. Field verification is pending.

Incident coordinator: Keep the suspected cause separate from confirmed impact. Who owns field coordination?

NOC engineer: The duty field supervisor. I'll provide circuit IDs and the latest topology information.

Incident coordinator: I'll maintain the incident timeline and issue the next update without inventing a restoration time.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Do we have a confirmed fault location or only correlated alarms?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Fiber deployment dependency

A rollout team encounters a blocked construction segment.

Roles: Deployment manager / Civil works coordinator

Deployment manager: The fiber crew is booked for Monday. Is the duct route ready?

Civil works coordinator: Not on the final segment. The permit condition requires clarification before excavation proceeds.

Deployment manager: Can the crew complete an independent section instead?

Civil works coordinator: Yes, if the revised work package and access arrangements are approved.

Deployment manager: I'll resequence the plan and flag the blocked dependency.

Civil works coordinator: I'll pursue the permit clarification and confirm which sections are actually released for work.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The fiber crew is booked for Monday. Is the duct route ready?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Capacity or coverage?

Engineers investigate complaints in a busy area.

Roles: Radio engineer / Network planner

Radio engineer: Signal strength looks acceptable, but users report slow data during the evening peak.

Network planner: That could be capacity rather than coverage. What do utilization and throughput trends show?

Radio engineer: Utilization rises at the same times, but we still need to check backhaul and interference.

Network planner: Compare the affected cells with neighboring sites and the same time windows.

Radio engineer: I'll prepare the evidence before proposing additional capacity.

Network planner: Include the assumptions and constraints so we don't choose a remedy from signal strength alone.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "That could be capacity rather than coverage. What do utilization and throughput trends show?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Provisioning mismatch

A service activation fails despite a completed order status.

Roles: Provisioning specialist / Service delivery manager

Provisioning specialist: The order is marked complete, but the customer's circuit isn't passing the acceptance test.

Service delivery manager: Which stage failed: configuration, physical connectivity, or test validation?

Provisioning specialist: The port configuration doesn't match the approved service profile.

Service delivery manager: Route the correction through the authorized change process and retain the test results.

Provisioning specialist: I'll verify the configuration and repeat the agreed acceptance checks after the change.

Service delivery manager: I'll keep customer acceptance pending and explain the next confirmed step to the account team.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Which stage failed: configuration, physical connectivity, or test validation?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Field dispatch handoff

A technician receives an incomplete fault ticket.

Roles: Field technician / Dispatch coordinator

Field technician: I have the site address, but no access contact or equipment reference.

Dispatch coordinator: I'll obtain both before confirming the visit. The ticket currently lists only the customer's billing address.

Field technician: Please also confirm whether any access restrictions or hazards are recorded.

Dispatch coordinator: I'll check the work order and required site arrangements.

Field technician: Once those are complete, I can assess the tools and skills needed for the job.

Dispatch coordinator: I'll update the ticket and send you the verified work location before dispatch.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "I have the site address, but no access contact or equipment reference." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Emergency-service change review

A network change has potential emergency-service implications.

Roles: Change manager / Compliance specialist

Change manager: This routing change affects a service used for emergency calling. Can it follow the ordinary release schedule?

Compliance specialist: It needs the applicable specialist review, testing, and coordination before approval.

Change manager: The current change record doesn't identify that dependency.

Compliance specialist: Add the affected services and ask the responsible engineering team to define the required evidence.

Change manager: I'll keep implementation pending and update the review group.

Compliance specialist: Record the approval conditions clearly; a successful general connectivity test isn't enough to close this issue.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "This routing change affects a service used for emergency calling. Can it follow the ordinary release schedule?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Churn-risk discussion

A service manager responds to a customer's repeated interruptions.

Roles: Account manager / Service assurance lead

Account manager: The customer is considering leaving after three outages. Can we promise there won't be another?

Service assurance lead: No. We can explain the confirmed incidents, completed improvements, and remaining work accurately.

Account manager: They also want a service-credit review.

Service assurance lead: Route that against the actual agreement and incident records; don't promise an amount before review.

Account manager: I'll arrange a meeting around the recovery actions and communication plan.

Service assurance lead: I'll bring the evidence and identify who owns each outstanding reliability action.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The customer is considering leaving after three outages. Can we promise there won't be another?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Equipment end of support

A network team plans replacement of aging equipment.

Roles: Network planner / Vendor manager

Network planner: The router family reaches end of support next year. Does that mean it stops operating then?

Vendor manager: No, but the vendor's support and update arrangements change. We need to verify the exact notice and dates.

Network planner: I'll map installed units and service dependencies.

Vendor manager: I'll confirm replacement options, lead times, and contractual support conditions.

Network planner: Then we can prioritize migration by exposure and business impact.

Vendor manager: Include test, rollback, and maintenance-window requirements in the plan before committing customer dates.

Notice the professional language

end of support - The point after which a supplier stops providing specified support for a product.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Network Operations and Outage Bridges

SHARED CASE

A network incident affects one service area. Fault isolation is ongoing, and no restoration estimate has been verified.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The affected area is identified, and fault isolation is continuing. We do not yet have a verified restoration estimate. I'll state the next update time and revise the message when confirmed information is available.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Fiber Deployment and Construction Coordination

SHARED CASE

A fiber installation team has completed physical work but an inspection is still pending. The next team assumes the route is ready.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

Physical installation is complete; the inspection remains pending. Please confirm the approved status before scheduling the next activity, and record the outstanding item in the handoff.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Wireless Capacity and Coverage

SHARED CASE

Customers report slow service in a busy area even though the coverage map shows signal availability.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Coverage and capacity describe different issues. A signal may be available while busy-period demand affects performance. I'll explain that distinction and report the observed conditions for investigation.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Provisioning and Service Activation

SHARED CASE

A service-activation request has a customer address but no circuit reference or requested activation date.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you confirm the circuit reference and target activation date? We need to match the request to the correct service and distinguish the requested date from a confirmed appointment.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Field Service and Dispatch

SHARED CASE

A field technician receives a ticket that says only "internet bad." The customer is available for a clarification call.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you describe what happens, when it occurs, and which devices are affected? Those details will help the field team prepare for the visit and avoid assumptions about the cause.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Regulatory and Emergency Services

SHARED CASE

A customer notice describes a regulatory requirement without citing the current approved wording. The responsible team has not reviewed it.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The notice needs review against the current applicable requirement and approved language. I'll identify the disputed wording and route it to the responsible team before release.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Customer Churn and Service Recovery

SHARED CASE

A customer asks for an update after repeated service interruptions. The investigation has no confirmed root cause.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'm sorry the interruptions have continued. The cause is still under investigation. I'll summarize the verified service history and confirm the next update rather than repeat an unverified explanation.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Vendor and Equipment Lifecycle

SHARED CASE

One equipment proposal has a lower purchase price but an earlier end-of-support date. The replacement plan extends beyond that date.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The lower price comes with a shorter support period. Let's compare the expected service life, support needs, and replacement timing before making the investment recommendation.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.